



BEFORE THEY LEAP (From left) Dolly, a Pashmi, and Leo, Jacky and Johnson, all Caravans, with their owners in Janwal

1 month

Average breeding season for the Pashmi

tures loping through the tawny rural landscape now draws dog lovers from across the country. It has changed the financial dynamics of this dusty village of 10,000 souls.

Yet the form of the trade, now that it's moving out of the few villages where it was formerly confined, has raised concerns over the well-being of the breeds—always in danger of their purity and quality being compromised. As the rest of India takes note and hankers for a prized puppy, it's time for the government and locals to do more.

BARK GOOD FOR BUSINESS

"Pashmi is an all-weather dog," says Pawar, whose family has been keeping the breed for more than 80 years. "As it has fur, it can survive in all three seasons." Pawar's ducks and hens roam freely, unafraid, and he does not lock the house whenever he steps out, as Malhar does not let anyone in. "Pashmis like to be handled only by their masters. Its bark is so loud and its posture so aggressive that a stranger would be deterred if it is around."

A puppy is born 62 days after mating; breeders keep the puppy for two months before selling it. "People come to us for advanced booking of a puppy. Every year, there is a waiting period," says Pawar. A puppy is sold at anywhere from Rs 12,000 to Rs 15,000. Most buyers are from Mumbai, Delhi, Gujarat, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. Some bureaucrats and politicians are regular buyers. On an average, they spend Rs 50,000 on a puppy, including price and transportation cost. "I had sold a puppy to a US resident two years ago. She came to Janwal after someone told her about the Pashmi breed." Tejas, the younger son of Maharashtra chief minister Uddhav Thackeray, too, had bought a black Pashmi from Janwal for Rs 23,000 eight months ago. Often, Pawar has not charged money for breeding. Instead, he takes a puppy to sell or gift it.

GREED IN VILLAGERS HAS LED TO EXCESSIVE INBREEDING, WHICH NOW POSES A THREAT TO THE SURVIVAL OF THESE TWO UNIQUE BREED OF DOGS

Farmer Ranjit Patil, owner of three Pashmi dogs, two males and one female, says its simple eating habits and clean nature is a reason why the breed is in demand. His favourite of the trio is Shera. "These dogs eat roti, eggs and drink milk like us," he says. "They'll never defecate in the house." Patil, too, does not charge for breeding, only accepts a puppy from those who seek his stud's services. "The Pashmis don't suffer from dehydration. They don't even need vaccination as they have strong natural immunity," he says, adding to the list of its qualities.

Jagannath Pawar, a grocery shop owner, also takes great pride in his Caravan, whom he calls Johnson. "Once it sets its eyes on his prey, it would hunt it, come what may," says a visibly proud Jagannath. Rabbit and deer are its favourite quarry. "The Caravan is more intelligent than a Labrador. It grabs a rabbit in its sharp teeth and retrieves it without mauling the game," he says. Jagannath, too, charges between Rs 3,000 and Rs 5,000 for breeding in the three-month-long breeding season. "One Caravan pup is sold at Rs 15-20,000 on an average. I use this money for running the shop. I don't need to take loans," he adds.

PASHMIS PAST AND PRESENT

The Pashmis are an Afghan breed. Many Pashtuns and Pashtun-related Rohillas, who came to India to work with the British, brought these dogs along with them in the late 19th century. Villagers in Janwal relate handed down tales about how the dogs first wandered into their village when the British were constructing a railway line between Parli (around 60 km away) and Hyderabad. Latur was a part of Hyderabad State before Independence. As the Pashtuns left for Hyderabad to take up service with the Nizam, they left the dogs behind. Ever since, the villagers have adopted them as their own.

The Caravans were brought to India from the US by Nanasaheb Ghorpade, ruler of the erstwhile Mudhol state, in the early 1900s. They are also known as Mudhol hounds. The breed of Caravan found in Janwal is also known as Bangadi Caravan, as its sleek head can pass through a bangle—or so the story goes.